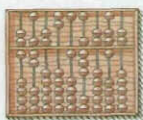


EDUCATION



FOR A SOCIETY TO SURVIVE and progress, each generation must pass its knowledge, skills, and values on to the next. This process is called education.

Passing on knowledge is so vital that most countries have established formal systems of education for teaching children, by sending them to schools and colleges.

Throughout our lives we are also educated informally, by parents, friends, or the media. Education provides society with doctors, teachers, and scientists; gives industry a capable workforce; and helps maintain law and order by instructing people in social values.

Early education

In prehistoric times, elders taught children the survival skills they needed, such as how to hunt or make fire. As civilizations developed and writing was invented, formal institutions of learning – schools – were created so that some people could learn to read and write.



The ancient world

As happens today, education in the ancient world reflected the state's needs and attitudes. In warlike Sparta, for example, education was geared towards producing good soldiers. Throughout the ancient world and medieval Europe, women and the poor did not have the same access to education enjoyed by the male, ruling classes.

Teacher and pupil, Romano-Germanic period

Theories of education

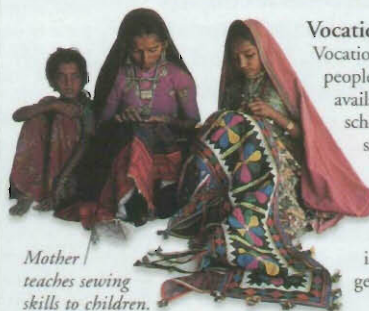
Some theories state that people learn by practice; others, that pupils must work things out themselves in order to learn; and some suggest that pupils learn by following their emotional needs and acquiring the skills and knowledge to fulfil them. Most people probably learn in all three ways.

Types of education

Different types of education cater for different needs. The best-known example is the general education that schools and colleges provide, in subjects such as reading, writing, and arithmetic.

Vocational

Vocational education prepares people for specific jobs; it is available through courses at school, or training at specific colleges. Skills or crafts are also passed on informally, perhaps from parent to child, when a trade is passed on from one generation to the next.



Mother teaches sewing skills to children.

Adult education

Adult education is for those who, although not full-time students, choose to continue an aspect of their education, or learn something new. The courses keep adults up-to-date, improve job prospects, and bring new interests.



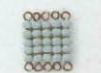
Learning computer skills

Special needs

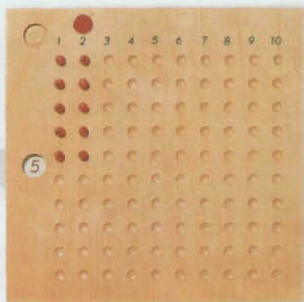
Wealthy nations can afford to provide some schools where education is tailored to the special needs of certain children, such as the physically challenged, or the highly-gifted.



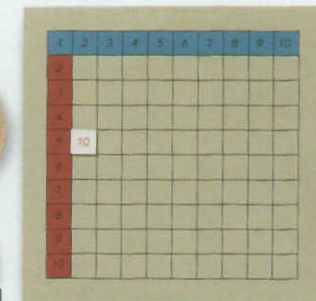
Disabled boy learns sailing skills.



Beads in number units



The child learns basic arithmetic skills by creative play with special, three-dimensional equipment.



Multiplication board

The Montessori system of education stresses that every child wants to learn. Children freely choose for themselves what and when to study.



Socialization

The first form of education a child receives starts from birth, by his or her immediate carers. Known as socialization, it includes not only learning such basic skills as speaking, but also teaches the child how society expects that he or she should behave. The child learns from instruction, and by imitating others. Socialization also takes place at school, and through cultural influences such as television.

Table manners are a learnt form of social behaviour.



Maria Montessori

The Italian educationist Maria Montessori (1870–1952) developed teaching methods that encouraged children to work things out for themselves through practical activity, rather than simply obeying instructions. She developed her ideas while working with children with learning difficulties.



Timeline

c.3500 BC Sumerians invent writing.

3rd century BC Greek thinker Plato (427BC–347BC) proposes that education should be run by the state.

1524 German priest Martin Luther (1483–1546) advocates education be made available for all, so that everyone is able to read the Bible.

1762 French philosopher Jean Jacques Rousseau (1712–1778) argues education should prepare children to be adults.

1763 Prussians introduce compulsory schooling from the ages of 5 to 13.

1899 US educator John Dewey (1859–1952) publishes *School and Society*, an influential analysis of the social function of education.

1945 World War II ends: with the desire to build a better world, many countries reform school systems to make secondary education available to all.

1990s Education is fully recognized as vital to social and economic growth.

FIND OUT MORE

CRIME

SCHOOLS AND COLLEGES

SOCIETIES

TRADE AND INDUSTRY

WRITING